Donkey Kong

G'day I am Warwick Schiller and welcome back to the principles of training. Today, the principle I want to talk about I call it the **Donkey Kong Principle**.

So I call it this principle *the Donkey Kong principle* based on the video game of Donkey Kong. Every video game is basically set up to teach you how to learn and I use you Donkey Kong as example because it's kind of my era and a lot of people that I teach are middle age like me. So we all get Donkey Kong we don't get call of battle 3 or something a rather, In Donkey Kong you are an ape of some sort and in the beginning you get fired out of a barrel, that's the start of the whole thing. When you first play the game and you start down this path, where you push the controller and you head this pathway and there's an alligator coming towards you. You get to the alligator and you're not sure what to do and you press a button that makes you squat down and the alligator kills you. What happens right then - the game stops and you go back to the start. You come out again and you've got to, you keep going up to that first obstacle which is the one alligator till you figure out which button to press to get you to jump. If you jump at the wrong time, the alligator kills you. You get back in the barrel again and you start alive again until you can jump that first alligator. OK, the most basic thing in Donkey Kong is jumping and jumping one thing at a time. So once you can jump that first alligator, I think, then you're going along and there are two alligators coming towards you and you have to jump both of them - one and then the other. I think it's both of them at the same time and initially when you try to jump over both of them you jump too early and you land on the second alligator and what happens? You die, and you go back and you get to practice jumping one alligator again. You get to practice that one jump again and then when you finally get to where you jump those two alligators you probably practiced that first one a lot more than you practiced the second one. Then you go along a little further and get to the next obstacle and with that next obstacle it's a little more tricky too and if you die there you don't get to keep going. You go back to the very beginning - you come back out and you've got to practice your first jump and your second jump. The whole Donkey Kong principle is all about - every time something goes wrong or every time you add something new - you make sure that you know everything leading up to that point.

That's what video games do. The way they're set them up is they really to teach you how to practice the basics. So the donkey Kong principle is basically how everybody's taught how to learn and just like with the Donkey Kong thing with a video game, you've got to learn the first thing before you're allowed to get to the second thing. Then when you get that wrong, you have to prove that you still know the first thing before you're allowed to get to the second thing. Once you get the second thing right, you get to the third thing. If you mess it up, you have to go back and practice the first and the second thing.

Now, I do a lot of clinics around the world and I have twelve people in my clinic - six in the morning group and six in the afternoon group. I always ask people, *so I'd like you to tell me your name and tell me what problem you'd like to solve with your horse.* I found that I would get to the third person when I'm learning the names in the morning or meeting the people in the morning, I'd get to the third person. I could remember the first person's name and I'd get to the sixth person and I couldn't remember everybody else's names. So, I would call people *hey you* for the next couple of days. So, I thought I needed to fix that. How would I go about teaching the horse something as complex as six particular things? So, I changed how I do the start of my clinics. Here is some footage from a recent clinic in Arizona, I will show you how I do that at the start of the clinics so remember everybody's names.

Okay so I need to know your name and where you are up to with your horse. So you are Kelvin. OK, you are Kathy, so he is got a bit of a puzzle. And you are Kathy so I got Kevin, Kathy and Bev so what is your horse's story. Its good you recognize that and you are Bev. So I have got Kelvin, Kathy, Bev. Craig how are you? Good so what is this one story that's probably good problem I will have to solve so you're Craig okay. Kevin, Kathy, Bev, Craig and Lori okay how are you? So you're Lori and I have got Kevin, Kathy, Bev, Craig, Lori and Mickey awesome, and you are Mickey. So I have Kevin, Kathy, Bev, Craig, Lori and Mickey you want to hear it again because I'm really good at this Kevin, Kathy, Bev, Craig, Lori, Mickey now everybody gives me a clap because I'm really clever.

That's on you to see what horses run around on the end of the lead when you guys clap so there is one of the first principles of training you need to know, which I call *the Donkey Kong principle.* That's one of the episodes I'm doing and let's go down here now. So Kelvin do you remember when I was talking to you the last thing I said to you? OK, probably put you in the wrong spot today but what I said to you before I went down there was *and you are Kelvin?* I made sure I knew this thing before I add any more information. OK, so this will be easy for you, Kathy. What was the last thing I said to you? I said *and you're Kathy* I made sure I knew that before I add any more information. So, when I said *and you're, Kathy* what did I do then? No, I didn't. I said *and you're Kathy, OK. So, we've got Kelvin and Kathy and hello young lady what's your name.* You said Bev. Now this will be easy for you, what was the last thing I said to you? No, I didn't go backwards I didn't go Kelvin, Kathy. I said *your Bev* and then what I did do then I said *OK we've got Kelvin, Kathy, Bev.* OK that's one piece of information and now all I have to do to get the fourth thing is add one more piece of information. I'm not adding four pieces of information together. Start out with Kelvin and that's a piece of information. Then I add Kelvin and Kathy, that becomes a piece of information. But I know Kelvin, Kathy. All I have to do is add one more and so think about that whole thing. How many times did I practice Kelvin's name? Five or six. How many times did I practice Mickey's name? Once. Mickey is the flying lead change. Mickey is the Holy Grail. Mickey is the hard thing that's easy by the time we get there. But there's a whole lot of work goes into all the basic stuff to get there. Does that make sense? The reason I call it the Donkey Kong principle, if you guys ever played a video game and the Donkey Kong is a video game that I played many years ago is you start out you're a monkey.

So then after I do that, usually right then, I'd go onto explain the whole Donkey Kong theory, but you saw when I was talking to those people that I said that Mickey is easy. Mickey is your Holy Grail. Mickey is you're flying lead change. Mickey's whatever it is, Mickey's usually hard for people but that hard thing is really quite easy by the time you get to it, if you can start at the beginning and learn your Kelvin's and your Kathy's and your Bev's. So one of the best examples of this Donkey Kong principle happened at a clinic a couple years ago in England and there was a young girl there with a horse and he was an eventer. He was an Irish Sport Horse. He was ten years old and he's been rather anxious all his life and likes to go forward and you've got to hang onto the reins to control him, to stop him from going fast. You know I don't think he's ever been ridden on a loose rein. If you turn loose, he would just run away. He was even like that on the ground. On the ground, I asked him to go and when I asked him to stop I actually couldn't get him to stop. I actually had to back up against a fence like this, so he was running around me and I backed up against the fence and I asked him to go again and the fence stopped him because I couldn't get him to stop. Then I would ask him to get over this way, he'd go around and that fence would stop him. So that afternoon, we got on to do the ridden work and I said before that I usually have two groups in my clinics, the morning group and afternoon group. She actually paid to have two

horses in the clinic but one of them wouldn't get into the truck to come to the clinic. So she got to be in both morning and afternoon group. So in the afternoon she got on and the first thing I wanted her to do, my Kelvin so to speak, is to get this horse to where he could just respond to this rein pressure, bend his head without him moving his feet. When she first started to do that she went to bend his head and he wouldn't bend his head, he'd just pull the reins out of her hand and walk around and around and around and around. She was pulling on him to bend his head, but he couldn't find the stop, he couldn't just stop and relax he couldn't just stand there and do that on the either side.

And so basically all she spent the whole afternoon, the first afternoon, four hours, basically working on getting her horse to where this part here works. That's basically her Kelvin. We came back the second day and she started using the Donkey Kong principle. She started back at the beginning again, how was your Kelvin and she got on and it wasn't great, but it took about probably fifteen twenty minutes till we could get what we had the first day. Now it took us four hours the first day to get to where we could do this and then the second day we came back and it took us about twenty minutes. Then we're going to add the next step, the Kathy okay. You think back to the second principle of training is you know when you get him up, get him back down again (Don't go to bed angry). So that's the down bit. If this horse couldn't stand still here on his own, on a loose rein, he's up. So, getting that part working was getting him down. Now we've got to get him responsive. So, what I had her work on then was, can you bend his head, now can you, say she was carrying a dressage whip, can you slide your leg back and have him respond to your leg? If he can't respond to your leg, tap him with the whip until he responds to it well. So, she slid a leg back, put a leg on, nothing happens. So, she tapped with a whip, nothing happened. Then she tapped with a whip and the finally untracked and then she took the leg off and, I'm going to make him do it, but then she spent the next fifteen minutes walking around in circles because he couldn't stop again. Once he got up, he couldn't get back down. He went around and around and finally he came to a stop. So, once he came to a stop, then we said, good. Now, how is your Kelvin? Does your Kelvin work? Yes, I can bend his head and he's not having to move his feet. Okay, so how is your Kathy? Which is the next step - can you get him up? She put a leg on him, he wouldn't go. If she tapped with a whip – tap, tap, when she got to moving she'd take a leg off and he couldn't come back down to a stop again. So, she spent the second morning from the beginning of the clinic to lunchtime working on Kathy. So basically, that's the principle of if you get him up can you get him down.

So once you get him responsive and you take your leg off you no longer ask him to go he should be able to find it back down again there's your two principles can you be relaxed and can you be a responsive if that is your Kevin and your Kathy in that case then we came back after lunch and we started asking him to walk around and she would ask him to walk just on the loose rein no steering just what we're working on here is in controlling himself this is the next step ask him to walk and what he would do is he would pick up the trot and trot off and she'd have to bend him around to till he stopped and she did that over and over and over till the thing about it when he bend he should stop and he relaxed really they have to be able to come back to relaxed state then after a while he would be walking along and he'd pick up the trot and trot off and she could bend him around and when he hit the walk you know so he go for a trot but asking she bend him when he hit the walk right there he was relaxed and she could actually let go at the walk so it was almost like she'd saved the first level in Donkey Kong and she is now working on the second level she didn't have to go over the first level again she could get that relaxation at the walk so we did that got the relaxation at the walk then we get to where we would ask her to trot and that horse would want to pick up the canter and so we'd bend the horse back to relax the trot then she got to it

when she had a relaxed trot. Then she would ask him to canter from the trot and as soon as he hit the canter she would bend him back to a trot but not just a trot but a relaxed trot and lot of times when she would steer him back to that trot, initially he was stiff like he didn't want to bend he didn't want to bend and it wasn't till he put a bend in these body these head hung down there relaxed and we practiced that over and over.

So once he could get into the canter and remain relaxed which means when he hit the canter it was very easy for him to bending back to a trot he wasn't stiff then we just let him canter around there for a while and at one point in time I said just drop the reins on his neck and put your hands on your head which she did and he just continued cruising around there and I said to her mother, how old is he? And she said ten and I said has he ever had anybody do that has anybody been able to drop the reins on his neck and stick their hands on their head and let him run away and she said certainly not, never. The first time we have tried to put the reins on his neck and stick your hands on your head and not steer him and he controlled himself so that's like your Mickey in the Donkey Kong theory. Once she cantered around and she could bend into a stop quite easily from a canter, which means he was relaxed at the canter and then I actually let the reins completely loose, I asked her to just use her seat to slow him down, he's cantering around she uses the seat and when she sits he gets canter canter trot trot and walk, stop. And so once he did that and we hadn't worked on that at all stuff at all that's easy once we did that then I would just to make an example I took the bridle off him so he's never been ridden without a bridle on before because he's always want to run away and so she asked him to I said go and ask him to walk so she walked he walked around I said you then ask him to trot, he trots around and I said go ahead and ask him to canter he canters around and when he came to us for the first time ever with no bridle on it bridle less he goes bottom bottom bottom just calm, nice and smooth and then when it looked like he was ready I said to her okay Emily just go ahead and sit, OK, and when she sits he goes from a canter to a trot to a walk to a stop and actually cocks its leg. This is a very very worried eventor who pulls like a train and he's ten years old he's an Irish sport horse and runs all the time and so the reason I think that's the best example of this is like I said in the beginning when I met those people at the clinic, Mickey is easy the last thing is easy you don't have to work any on Mickey and if you think a bit in this case right here, she spent four hours the first day working on getting your horse to stand still while the baby's head then she spent the next four hours the next morning working on can you stand still while your bend his head then can he be responsible off your leg and when you take your leg off can he come back down to be relaxed again so that's the whole you know don't go to bed angry when you get him up can you get him back down. Once he had the ability to get up and down the rest of it was easy and like I said the last thing she did was ride this horse around with no bridle on and slow him down off the seat the first time she'd ever tried it and it worked.

One place you can use this Donkey Kong principle and I use a lot is in the desensitizing of horses and I think where people have trouble with desensitizing horses is they fail to do the Donkey Kong principle of when the horse gets it wrong they fail to go back to the start. So if I was going to desensitize a horse say that this if I want out to cracking this Australian stock whip here right down beside my horse that wouldn't be the place I would start I would have desensitized with the lead rope and stuff but then if I can take this thing and just a flap it on the ground like that I'm directly in front of my horse with my horse is twelve o'clock this and this is a big clock on the ground here, this is three o'clock is he good at three o'clock if he's good at three o'clock is he good at two forty five if he's good at two forty five is he good at two thirty he is good at two thirty is he good at two fifteen yes he's good at two fifteen he good

at two yes he's good at two, is he good at two forty five right there see his head came up he got a little bit bad right here and this is one forty five I am going to wait till he blinks or gives me some indication that he's starting to relax again okay I am ust going to stay here cause he's right now he's getting it wrong he's not there again he just blinked and lowered his head slightly so I'm going to quit then were am going to start again we're going to get back to the beginning and go back to three o'clock and he made a mistake at one forty five he's done this before hasn't done that in a long time but he's done it before but I got to one forty five and I had a problem, sometimes that problem can be at two forty five and so am going to start at three he's good with that I'm going to get up two forty five he's good with that I'm going to get him to two thirty he's good with that I'm watching his head OK he's head and at two fifteen he is good with that at two o'clock he's good with that one forty five, this is where he was bad last time was he and he is good with that now at one thirty he's good with that now am at one twenty five and one he's good with that, at twelve forty five and right then he just had a big sign and told me relax I'm not even quit right there not that I normally would always do that but right thing so I just got to the scary part and he sighed. So it got really close to him he went and he start to get a bit concerned back here at one forty five I think it was and I didn't keep going there I waited till he got better and then I retreated back it's like Donkey Kong and so now I'm am on three o'clock to forty five to thirty to fifteen to one forty five one thirty one fifteen one, twelve forty five, twelve thirty, twelve fifteen and there we are. OK twelve o'clock would be cracking him down so he's good with that so then what I could do is I could start out here with my cracking at my three o'clock he's good at three, so I would do three and do two forty five, if he is good at two forty five will do to two thirty, if he is good at two thirty I'll do two fifteen, if he is good at two fifteen I'll get to two, if he is good at two I will go to one forty five.

And remember this is where he, just think about that for a second this is where he had trouble I mean again he got stuck right here but not with the lead cracking just with this whipping noise and because when he got stuck right there I wanted it to get unstuck and went back to the start the second time around with the whip so this is a bigger thing like a Mickey. OK I started with Kelvin this is like a Mickey type thing this is the big thing it was quite easy for him so I will just stop were am I going to start again am going to start over here at three, two forty five, two thirty, two fifteen, two, one forty five, one thirty, one fifteen, one, twelve forty five, twelve thirty, twelve fifteen and he hasn’t moved a muscle so you see he was, think about it that would be the hardest thing to do crack it right there but because I noticed doing something simpler like this where it went wrong right here I waited till he got good again and then I retreated and started all over again that's what I believe to crack that we've done to be Saudi and I think were we are wrong is if you we are doing this slightly up tight right here you go he's not too bad I'll just keep going and keep going and keep going and keep going and then it all falls to pieces. So the secret to that sort of thing is just do Donkey Kong theory and when it get it wrong like you said when up we're going to a little bit tight as soon as you get it right relaxed again I stop and start again. If you think about when you got up tight and he relaxed again I stopped and started again and it takes the pressure off him and what principle of training is that that is the don't go to bed angry we talked about that in the second episode it was the second principle we talked about don't go to bed angry if you get him up get him back then again and getting closer to him get him slightly up then he got good with it I took the pressure off let him back down and start all over again.

So I hope that gives you a bit of an idea of the principle of training that I call the Donkey Kong principle. Don't forget to join us next time and we'll talk about another principle of training.